

What is a Virtual Learning Environment (VLE)?

A **Virtual Learning Environment (VLE)** is a collaborative platform that enables better learning delivery. It helps educators work more efficiently and allows students to complete schoolwork from anywhere.

Typical Features of a VLE

- **Web and mobile applications:** Allow learners to access courses from anywhere at any time.
- **Highly collaborative features:** Includes virtual classrooms, email applications, chat forums, wikis, blogs, and leaderboards.
- **Innovative lesson delivery:** Utilizes gamified instruction and flipped classrooms (reversing the traditional homework-first format).
- **Synchronous and asynchronous learning:** Combines real-time interaction (e.g., meeting for the first 15 minutes) with independent study.
- **Offline learning capabilities:** Allows creation of electronic records offline when internet access is poor, which synchronize once a connection is available.

Importance of a VLE

1. **Track learner performance easily:** Electronic records and assessments allow teachers to track student progress and submissions.
2. **Deliver content consistently:** The same materials are accessible to all learners and can be easily updated.
3. **Save cost and time:** Content is created once and shared digitally without printing costs.
4. **Encourage communication and collaboration:** Forums and message boards foster a sense of community.
5. **Promote flexible learning:** Students can learn on their own time and review unclear topics.
6. **Provide a way to explore and experiment:** Instructors can innovate new teaching techniques.

Use of Open Learning Websites

Open learning websites offer online courses at a fraction of the cost of traditional institutions. Examples include:

- **Khan Academy:** A non-profit providing free, world-class education for anyone, covering kindergarten through early college topics (math, science, grammar, etc.).
- **edX:** Founded by Harvard and MIT; a global non-profit offering free and fee-based courses from top-ranked universities using an open-source platform.
- **Coursera:** Features university partners offering courses, specializations, and degrees (ranging from free to paid options).
- **Udemy:** A global education marketplace driven by content creators who curate and teach their own courses.
- **TED-Ed:** TED's youth and education arm that uses original animated videos and a platform for teachers to create interactive lessons.
- **Codecademy:** An interactive platform focusing on coding and programming languages (web development, data science, etc.).

Evaluating Web Pages

Unlike print materials, information on the web does not always have strict quality control standards. It is crucial to evaluate web pages using **five core criteria**:

Criterion	Key Evaluation Questions & Focus
1. Accuracy	Who wrote the page? Is the person qualified? Can you contact them via email or address?
2. Authority	Which institution published the document? What are their credentials? Check the URL domain: preferred domains include .edu , .gov , and .org .
3. Objectivity / Credibility	What goals or objectives does the site meet? Is the page a mask for advertising? (If so, it might be biased).
4. Currency / Current	When was the site produced and last updated? Are there dead links on the page?
5. Coverage / Functionality	Can you view the information properly without being restricted by fees, browser technology, or software requirements?

